

Marketing for Betterment and Shield of Eden

A brief for the ESSEC Research Support team

The problem: an incomplete measure of success

Marketing has become systematic. Firms combine behavioural data, algorithmic targeting and continuous online experimentation to optimise messages, prices and interface designs. These optimisations are evaluated almost exclusively against commercial outcomes such as conversion, engagement and retention. Their consequences for the people exposed to them are rarely measured, and therefore rarely enter decision-making.

Research and public debate point to consequences at three levels: **individual** (mental health, self-perception, time and attention), **societal** (materialistic values, polarisation, erosion of trust) and **environmental** (overconsumption, waste, emissions). Many of the techniques involved, such as pre-selected defaults, countdown timers, scarcity cues, reference prices and asymmetric cancellation flows, are effective precisely because they operate below conscious awareness.

A self-reinforcing equilibrium

We treat the persistence of these practices as a coordination problem rather than a failure of intent. Four groups act reasonably under their own constraints, and each constraint sustains the others.

Consumers

Because the techniques are low in salience, harm is rarely perceived and there is little demand for change. Those who do notice have no means to respond, and tend to discount the effect.

Firms

Restraint carries a competitive cost. Without a shared standard or independent assessment, responsible practice cannot be credibly signalled to customers.

Researchers

Behavioural data and experimentation infrastructure sit inside firms. Academic work relies largely on surveys, laboratory studies and small samples, which are weakest where causal claims are most needed: in real settings and over time.

Regulators

Without a causal evidence base, proportionate rules are difficult to draft and defend. Techniques vary by degree rather than in kind, and their effects differ from one person to another.

An intervention at a single point is therefore absorbed by the others. Change requires several levers to move together, supported by what none of the four groups can provide alone: independent instruments and independent evidence.

Our approach

Marketing for Betterment is a non-profit initiative based in Paris. Its vision:

"A world where marketing enriches lives, sustains the planet, and drives prosperity."

Its mission is to steer marketing toward individual, societal and planetary well-being through three mutually reinforcing pillars:

Creating awareness

Recognition reduces the effectiveness of many persuasion techniques, and informed consumers create demand for responsible practice. Awareness is paired with practical means to act, since awareness alone tends to produce resignation.

Fostering scientific research

Shared infrastructure for randomised field experiments on live websites, with participant cohorts and standardised protocols, so that independent teams can produce causal evidence without depending on a commercial partner.

Developing tools, technologies and standards

Consumer-controlled tools and, over time, shared definitions, measurement methods and evidence-based thresholds. These make independent assessment possible: the credible signal that responsible firms lack.

Our premise is not that marketing is harmful in itself, but that its evaluation is incomplete. Since most techniques are quickly imitated and confer little lasting advantage, a credible standard would benefit most firms too.



Shield of Eden: a field laboratory

Shield of Eden is a privacy-first Chrome extension connected to a server-side research platform. It works as a field laboratory for studying digital persuasion in authentic environments, and as a personal tool that lets users see and modify manipulative elements on the websites they already use.

For individuals

While users browse, Shield of Eden detects the marketing techniques it knows and explains how each one works. Users then decide how to respond: they can be warned, or have the element removed or reshaped. Gamified lessons in the Learning Center build the ability to recognise these techniques without the tool, and the insights panel shows users their own usage behaviour, such as the time they spend on each website. Participation also turns into real-world tree planting.

Our goal is to raise awareness and give individuals practical means to act. Because recognition reduces the effectiveness of many persuasion techniques, better-informed users make these techniques less effective and create demand for more responsible practice. The platform also brings the latest research findings directly to the people they concern.

For research institutes

Shield of Eden gives researchers independent access to field experimentation, without the need for a commercial partner. Teams can recruit invitation-based cohorts across universities and run randomised A/B tests on live websites, several at once. They can combine passive behavioural data with short questionnaires triggered by specific events, and follow metrics they define themselves over time. AI-assisted analysis and reporting is in development.

Our goal is a platform that is open to all universities: a standard environment for causal experiments in which hypotheses can be tested quickly and reliably. The evidence it produces can then inform standards in marketing and the regulation of digital platforms. More broadly, we hope it moves marketing research toward the field, where these effects actually occur.

Ethics and consent. Protection works without any data sharing. Data collection, experiments and questionnaires are three independent opt-ins, off by default, and personal identifiers are removed before storage. In a course, educational use and research participation are kept separate: contributing is a private opt-in, invisible to the instructor and without effect on grades. All studies go through ethics review.

Status and collaboration with ESSEC

A working MVP has been built and is in invite-only testing, where it is being tuned based on user feedback. We aim to run a first pilot with ESSEC students in winter 2027.

Next steps. Discuss the project with ESSEC and Metalab, obtain the necessary approvals, including ethics review, and run the pilot with a sample of ESSEC students.

What we need.

- Financial support, as our team is based in Iran.
- An institutional home at ESSEC, such as a lab or research centre, giving the project the formal standing required for ethics review, data protection and funding applications.
- Guidance on internal and external funding: for example ANR, CY projects, ESSEC internal calls, and other options such as doctoral co-funding or European education partnerships.

We would welcome the opportunity to discuss how we can work together.